

Parts Used Aerial parts, essential oil.

Constituents Oregano contains a volatile oil (comprising carvacrol, thymol, beta-bisabolene, caryophyllene, linalool, and borneol), tannins, resin, sterols, and flavonoids. Both carvacrol and thymol are antibacterial and antifungal.

History & Folklore Esteemed by the ancient Greeks, oregano was considered a cure-all in medieval times. It was one of the medicinal plants cultivated by early New England settlers.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Oregano and its oil are strongly antiseptic with potent activity against many bacteria and fungi, notably *E. coli* and *Candida* strains. It can aid many acute and chronic infections affecting the gastrointestinal and respiratory tracts, especially gastroenteritis, dysentery, bronchitis, coughs, and tonsillitis. Both herb and oil inhibit the gut flora (bacteria naturally occurring within the gut) and have an important role to play in gut dysbiosis, a condition where the presence of harmful gut bacteria leads to symptoms such as gas, bloating, and abdominal discomfort. The diluted oil can be applied to toothache or painful joints.

Cautions Do not take as a medicine during pregnancy. External use may cause irritation of the skin. Do not take essential oil internally.

Orthosiphon aristata (Lamiaceae) Java Tea

Description Shrub growing to about 3 ft (1 m). Has pointed leaves and lilac-colored flowers with very long stamens.

Habitat & Cultivation Java tea is native to Southeast Asia and Australia. Now cultivated as a medicinal plant, it is picked as required throughout the year.

Part Used Leaves.

Constituents Java tea contains flavones (including sinensetin), a glycoside (orthosiphonin), a volatile oil, and large amounts of potassium.

History & Folklore The plant's Dutch Indonesian name, *koemis koetjing* (cat's whiskers), probably derives from its long whiskery stamens.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Java tea is listed in the French, Indonesian, Dutch, and Swiss pharmacopoeias (official documents containing a list of drugs and their medicinal uses, preparations, and dosages). It is thought to increase the kidneys' ability to eliminate nitrogen-containing compounds. The herb is much used as a diuretic and as a treatment for kidney infections, stones, and poor renal function resulting from chronic nephritis. It is also used to treat cystitis and urethritis.

Research Java tea's diuretic activity has been confirmed in scientific experiments. Extracts significantly increase potassium levels in the urine.

Paeonia officinalis (Paeoniaceae) Peony

Description Perennial growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has a tuberous root, upright stems, oval to lance-shaped leaflets, and attractive large red, red-purple or white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation A native of southern Europe, peony grows in mountain woodlands and is widely cultivated. The root is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Peony is thought to contain alkaloids, tannins, saponins, flavonoids and triterpenoids, and a volatile oil.

History & Folklore Since the time of Hippocrates (470–377 BCE), peony has been used to treat epilepsy. Ibn el Beitar, a medieval Arab physician, recommended a necklace of peony seeds to ward off epilepsy in children. Mrs. Grieve, the author of *A Modern Herbal* (1931), recounted how "in ancient times, peony was thought to be of divine origin, an emanation from the moon, and to shine during the night protecting the shepherds and their flocks."



Peony is named after Paeon, the physician of the Greek gods.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though little used in contemporary European herbal medicine, Peony is greatly valued within Unani herbal medicine from the Middle East. It has anti-inflammatory, antispasmodic, and sedative activity, and is prescribed for conditions as varied as nervous debility, epilepsy, and high blood pressure, and as a heart tonic. The root has also been taken to treat whooping cough, and suppositories are made of the root to relieve anal and intestinal spasms.

Related Species Chinese peony (*Paeonia lactiflora*, p. 117) is much used in Chinese herbal medicine.

⚠ **Cautions** Take peony only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.

Panax notoginseng (Araliaceae) Notoginseng, San Qi (Chinese)

Description Deciduous perennial with an erect stem growing to 3 ft (1 m), compound leaves, small greenish flowers, and small, berrylike fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China, notoginseng is now rare in the wild. It is cultivated commercially in southern and central China. The root is unearthed before flowering or after the fruit has ripened.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Notoginseng contains steroidal saponins, polysaccharides, and a flavonoid.

History & Folklore Despite its importance as a tonic, notoginseng was only recorded in Chinese herbal medicine in 1578, in the *Compendium of Materia Medica* by Li Shizen. He described the root as being "more valuable than gold."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Like ginseng (*P. ginseng*, p. 118), notoginseng is a tonic that supports the function of the adrenal glands, in particular the production of corticosteroids and male sex hormones. Notoginseng also helps to improve blood flow through the coronary arteries, thus finding use as a treatment for arteriosclerosis, high blood pressure, and angina. Notoginseng treats internal bleeding of almost any kind. The herb may also be applied externally as a poultice to help speed the healing of wounds and bruises.

Research Clinical studies have confirmed notoginseng's longstanding reputation as a means to arrest bleeding. A Chinese trial indicated that the herb hastens blood clotting. Another clinical trial and extensive scientific studies, again in China, associated the herb with positive improvements in coronary circulation, in lessening the symptoms of angina, and in the reduction of blood pressure levels. In common with other ginseng-type herbs, notoginseng has been shown to enhance physical performance.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Panax quinquefolium (Araliaceae) American Ginseng

Description Deciduous perennial growing to about 1 ft (30 cm). Has a smooth stem, leaves with oblong to oval leaflets, small greenish flowers, and kidney-shaped scarlet-red berries.

Habitat & Cultivation American ginseng is native to North America and the Himalayas. A woodland plant, it is rarely seen in the wild due to overharvesting. It is cultivated in Wisconsin, China, and France. The root is gathered in autumn.

Part Used Root.